

Maize streak virus

Recognize the problem

Maize streak virus disease is common in Kenya, especially in the lowlands in winter.

You can see the sickness on the top and bottom surface of the leaves. The leaves have yellowish and light green streaks on young plants and whitish, yellow and light green streaks on mature plants running along their surface, in the direction of the leaf veins.

If the plant is attacked early, then it will be grow less, and the harvest will be poor. Sick plants are smaller, especially if attacked early after planting. A sick field will produce a smaller harvest.

The leaves of a young plant show some yellow and light green streaking on the leaves.



Background

Maize streak virus disease is caused by a kind of germ called a **virus**. This virus is transmitted by a leaf hopper: a brownish white insect that lives on the maize leaf and is smaller than a mosquito.

The more leaf hoppers there are in your field, the quicker and more serious the disease will spread.

Some varieties are not affected by the disease because they are able to defend themselves against the virus and give a good yield even if the disease is there. These are called **resistant** varieties.

White, yellow and light green streaking on the leaf and reduced size of the corm is visible on the mature maize.



Management

- Inspect the field often, when the maize is small, looking for diseased plants. Uproot infected plants when they first show signs of disease. This will keep the disease from spreading to healthy plants. Put the whole plant in a sack so the whiteflies do not go to other plants. You can feed the plants to your animals.
- For the next growing season, if the problem was bad, it is important to plant resistant maize varieties next season. They are developed by and available at Kenya Agricultural Research Institute (KARI) and Kenya Seed Limited. The resistant varieties are: **KH634A**, **KH633A**, **KH500-31** and **KH500-32**.

Scientific name(s) > **Maize streak virus**

The recommendations in this factsheet are relevant to: Ghana, Kenya

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